Project Proposal: Museum of Theft

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Concept: This pop-up museum examines how the meaning of “theft” changes depending on what is stolen, who steals it, who defines the act and who gets to own or tell its history. The exhibition will begin with a case of physical theft and gradually complicate the visitor’s understanding through historical cases of stolen artifacts and the labelling of resistance as crime. Other elements being considered for exhibition are: the Kakori conspiracy, the history of origin of everyday items like tea, rubber and turmeric, and the taking of cultural objects such as the Benin Bronzes. The narrative will then move into cybercrime and digital theft, where the same questions must be reconsidered in the current era, a world where the theft of information, data and digital property is considered just as detrimental as that of physical objects. We intend for the visitor to ponder upon whether such claims of "theft" are primarily legal, rational, based on historical rights or shaped by questions of identity and emotional attachment. These questions become harder over the course of the exhibits, where the same acts of taking differ depending on what is taken and who is doing the judging.

Significance: The exhibition ultimately turns this question towards the visitor themselves: when theft becomes intangible or normalised, can we recognise when we are participating in it, benefiting from it, or even contributing to it? This is what makes the topic relevant; most visitors already live inside forms of theft (data, digital property, cultural appropriation) that they have never been asked to examine as theft. These cases are not closed; the Benin Bronzes remain the subject of restitution claims today. Who has the authority to call an act theft, and to own or narrate its history, is a central question of public history; the digital section carries that question into data ownership, where it is being contested right now.

Vision of the Exhibition: The museum will be organised as a progression rather than a collection of unrelated examples. Each major section will present a historical story through *images, paintings, documents, physical objects or reproductions*. For some of the major cases, an *audio guide* will provide the historical context and describe the central question alongside a key image or artifact, allowing visitors to relate the scene with the text seamlessly. Each story builds on the previously-built idea of theft in the mind of the visitor meaningfully. Every section will therefore examine a different dimension of theft, i.e., *what can be stolen, who gets called a thief, whether legality plays a role, what it means to own a culture and who has the authority to*

define ownership, before applying those ideas to interpret forms of digital theft in the present. The general aim is for visitors to understand *how and why different forms of theft have been defined and contested in their historical contexts*, rather than simply being told what to think about them.